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R Courses in Public Administration: Learning Success or Flash in the Pan?

Felix Lorenz, Swiss Statistics Days 2026



A Survey in Four Cantons as a Starting Point

- The survey was distributed to R course graduates in the cantons of Thurgau, Basel-Landschaft, Basel-Stadt, and Zürich
- A total of 58 responses

Key question: What is the medium- and long-term benefit of R courses?

Four Programs, One Survey

Very similar in content

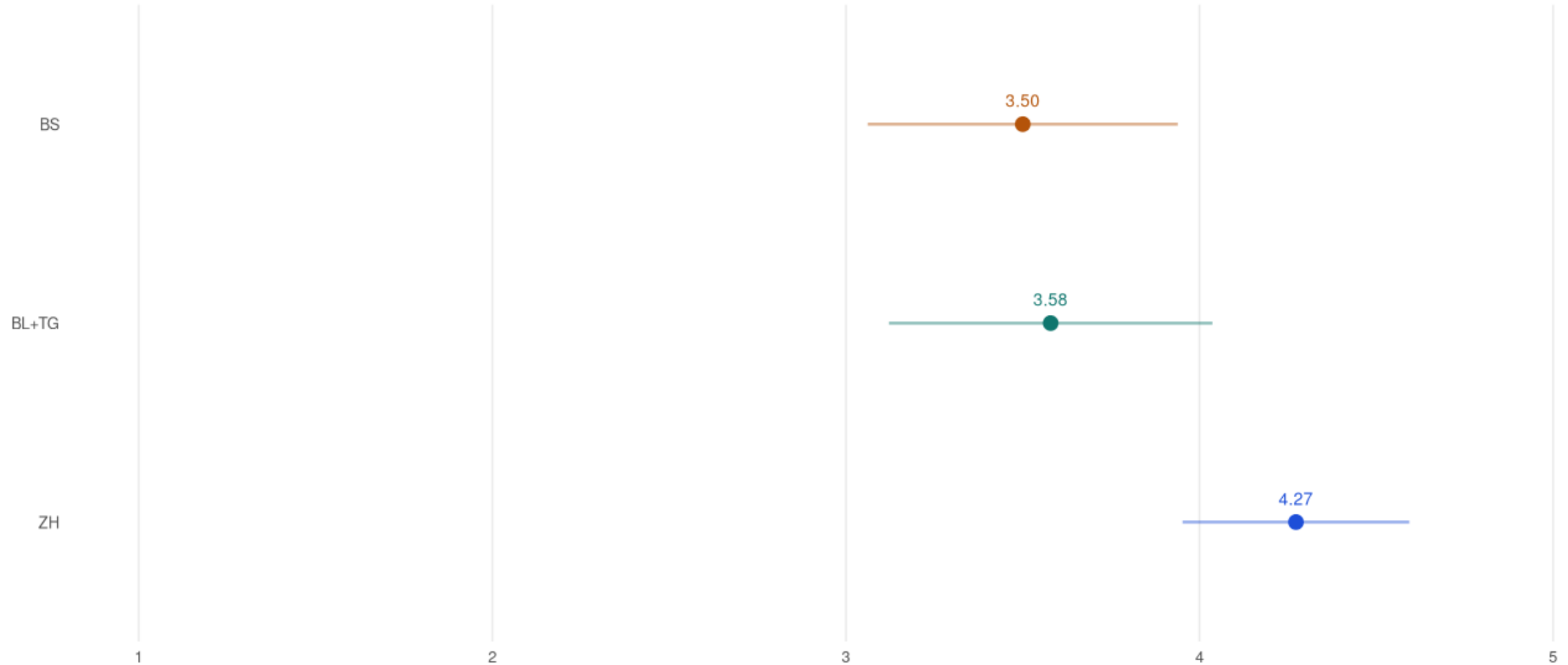
	BS	BL+TG	ZH
Format	Half-day introductory course	6 modules of 3.5 h each	10 modules of 2.5 h each
Self-study time announced	–	not specified	~3 h per module
Final project	no	no	yes (+ 2 weeks before/after)
Cost	none	none	CHF 1,950
Responses	16	19	22

The three course formats are evaluated separately but are NOT(!) ranked against each other. The three formats effectively represent three different "dosages": course time, commitment, self-directed effort and cost increase from BS through BL+TG to ZH.

Most participants are satisfied with the course

F8b – Gesamtzufriedenheit mit dem Kurs

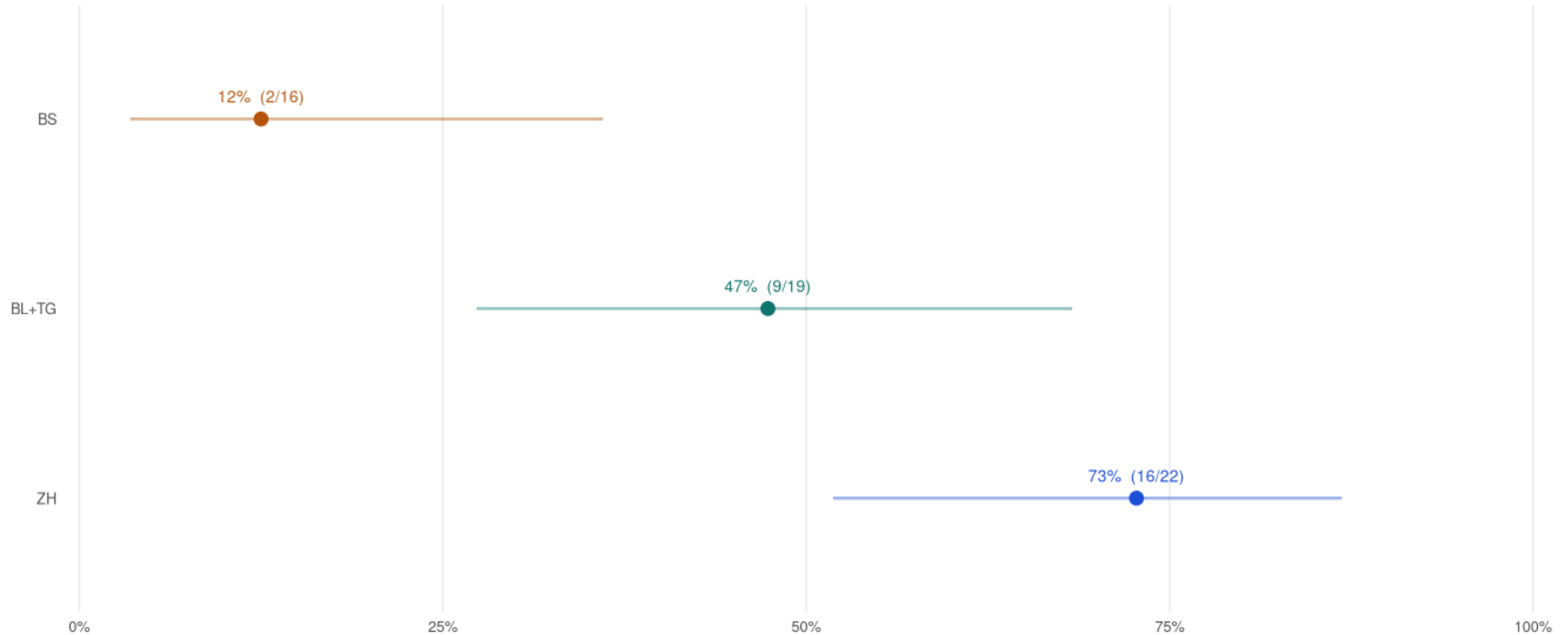
Mittelwert mit 95%-Intervall, Skala 1–5



Who still uses R at all?

Anteil, der R seit dem Kurs überhaupt nutzt

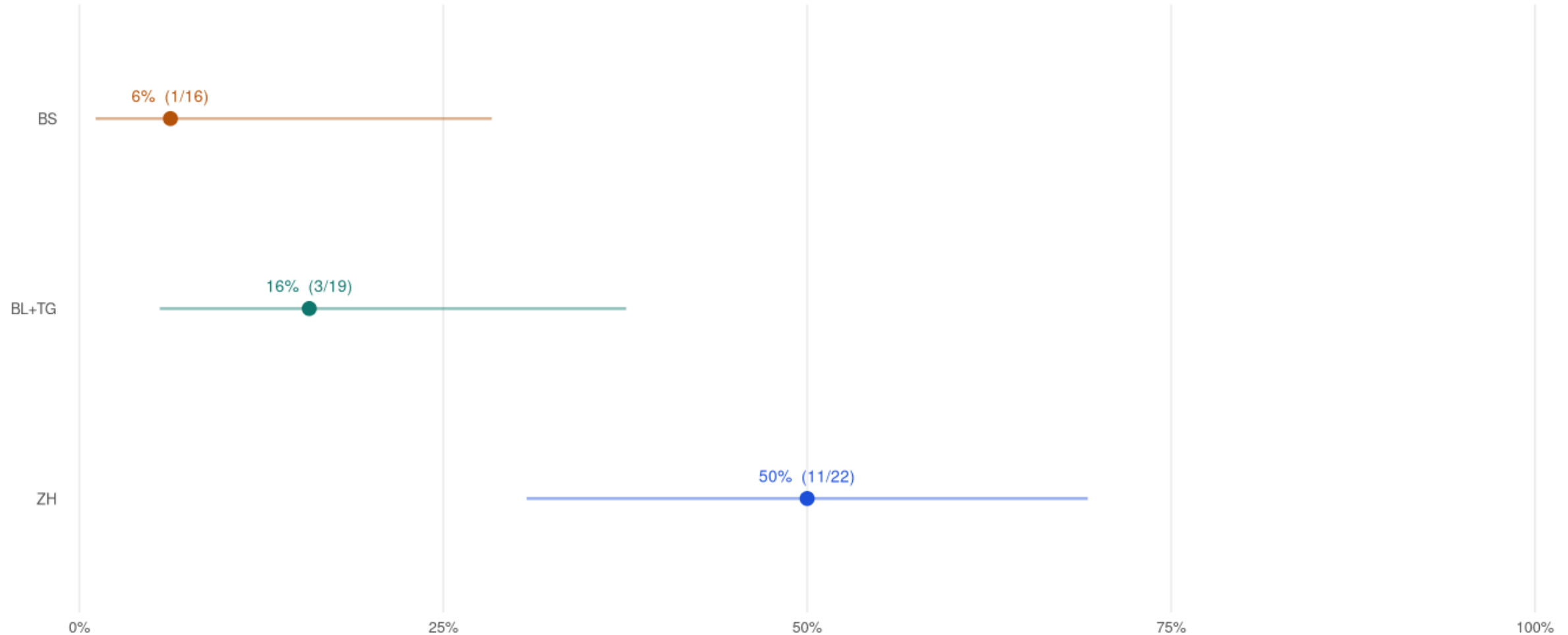
Punkt = Anteil, Linie = 95%-Wilson-Intervall



Who uses R regularly?

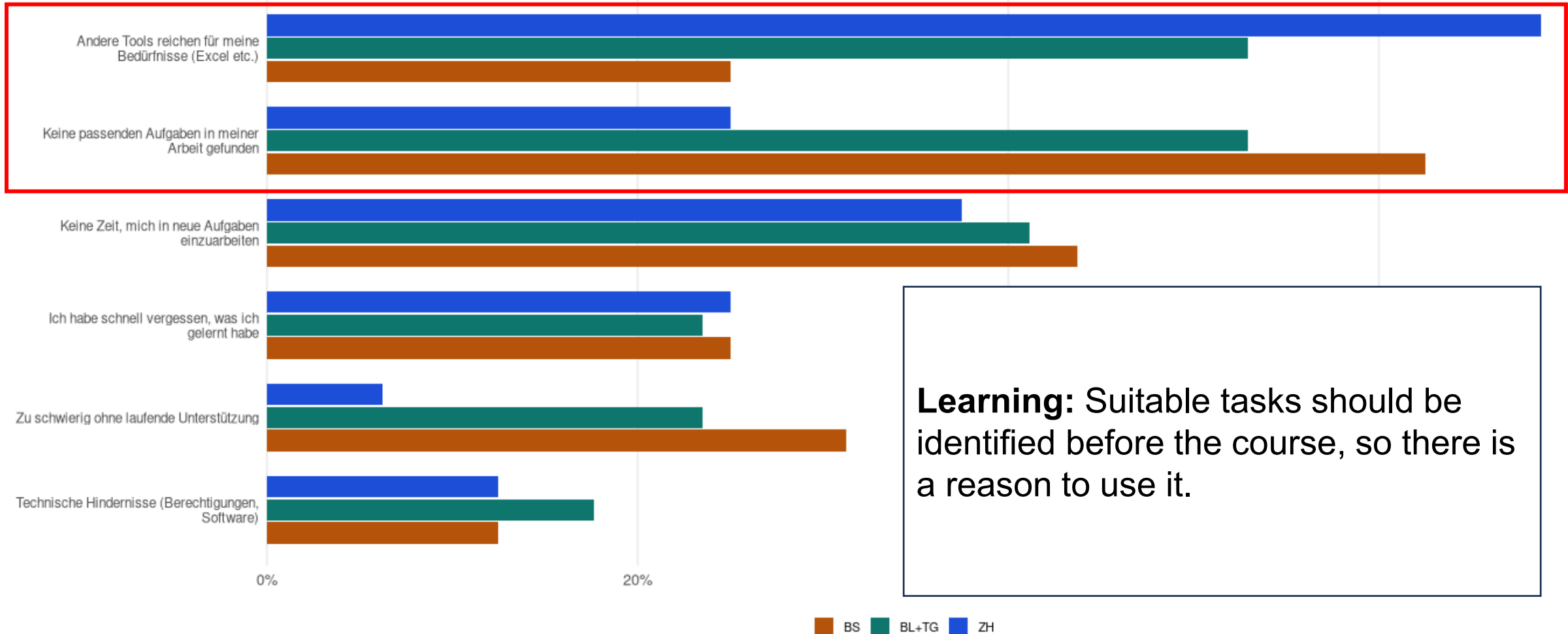
Anteil mit mindestens gelegentlicher Nutzung ($\geq 1-3\times$ pro Monat)

Punkt = Anteil, Linie = 95%-Wilson-Intervall



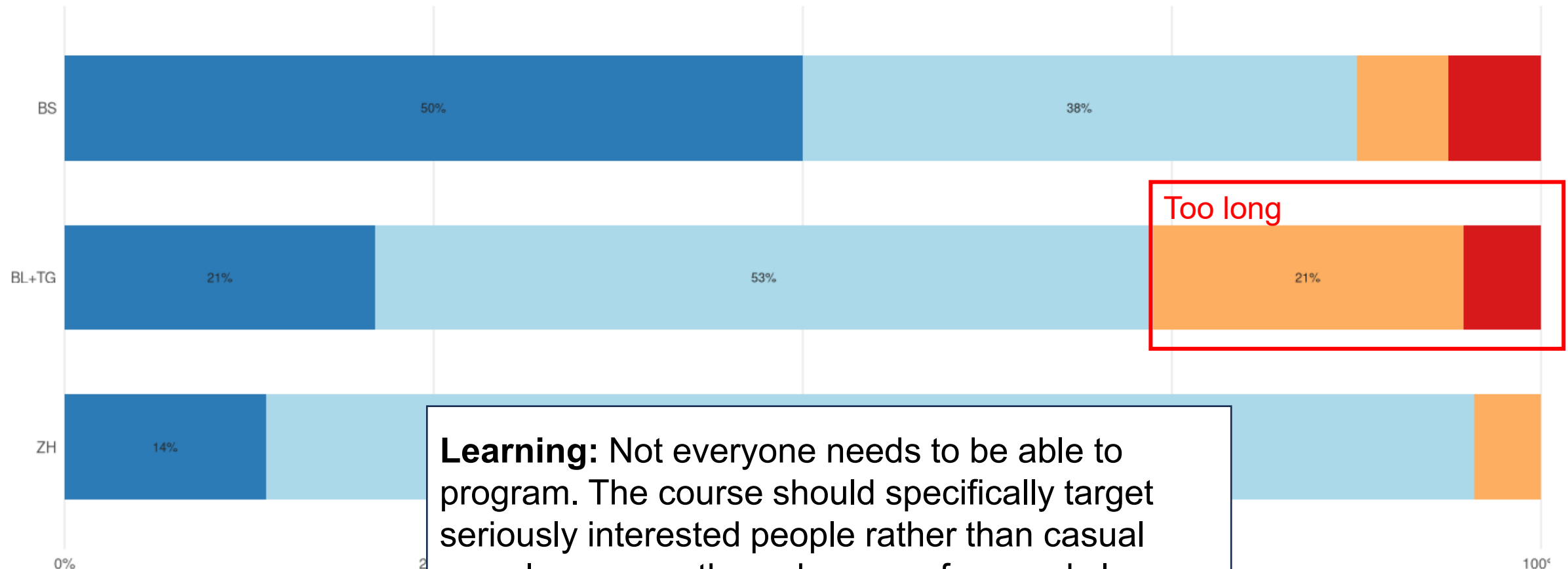
Many don't know what to use R for

F1a – Was hat dich daran gehindert, R zu nutzen?



"Open" courses lead to heterogeneous target groups?

F7b – War der Umfang des Kurses für dich persönlich...

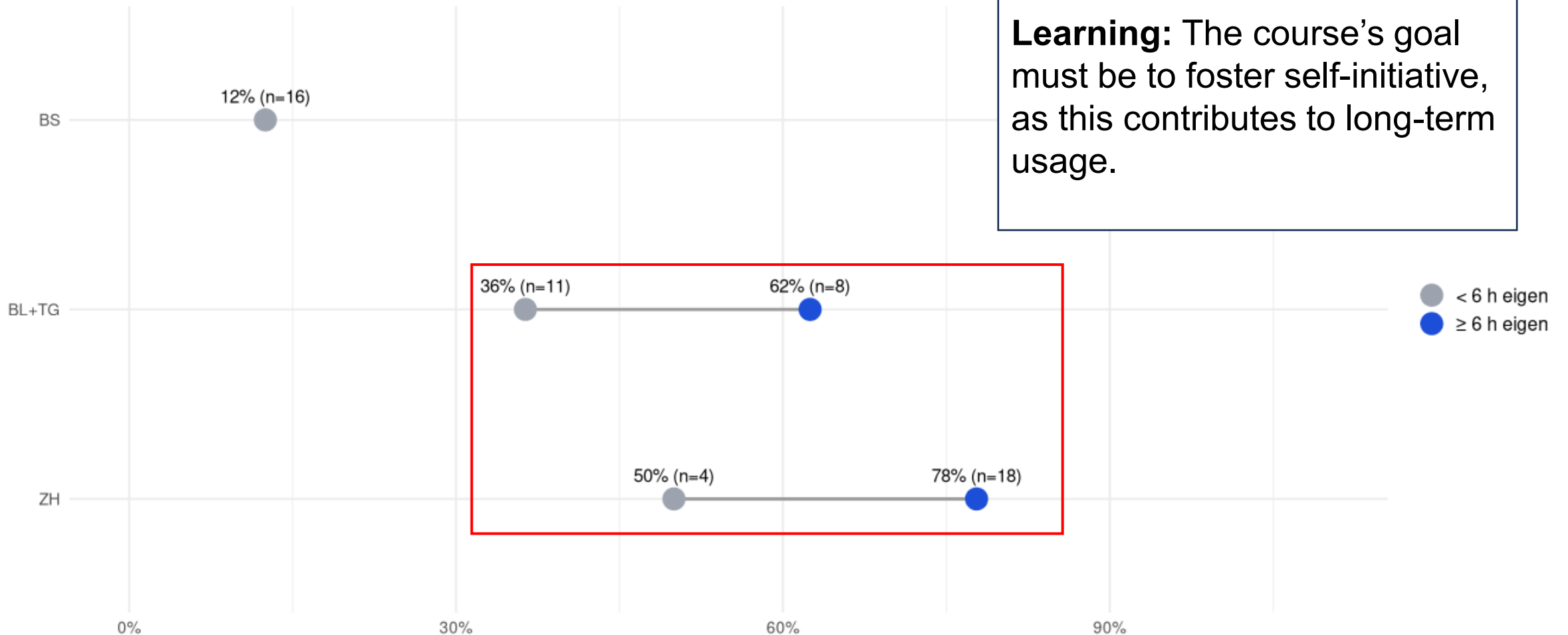


Learning: Not everyone needs to be able to program. The course should specifically target seriously interested people rather than casual samplers – e.g., through course fees and clear communication of the time commitment.

Increased self-directed effort leads to more sustainable usage

Nutzung heute nach Eigenaufwand, innerhalb der Kursform

sehr kleine Teilgruppen – nur als Hinweis lesbar



Learning: The course's goal must be to foster self-initiative, as this contributes to long-term usage.

Three Learnings for more sustainable use



Own projects as a basic prerequisite for participation



Specifically target genuinely interested and motivated colleagues



Foster self-initiative and communicate time commitment clearly

What this means for course design



Own projects as a basic prerequisite for participation

- Preliminary workshop (separate from the R workshop)
- Conceptual identification of automatable work steps/projects
- Goal: identify an automatable project from one's own area of work



Specifically target genuinely interested and motivated colleagues

- Charge course fees, also to counteract no-shows
- Participation in the preliminary workshop as a prerequisite (or with own project)



Foster self-initiative and communicate time commitment clearly

- Implement own project as the final project
- Follow-up support (R office hours, community, etc.)

Thank you!



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